

Skin Problems



Calendula
(*Calendula officinalis*)

The largest organ of the body, the skin protects against heat, cold, infection, and trauma from the outside world. Although continuously shedding its surface, the skin needs regular cleansing and nourishing to remain healthy. Its ability to resist injury and recover from damage largely depends on the health of the body as a whole. While many minor skin problems respond promptly to simple external remedies, severe or chronic skin conditions need internal treatment and usually require professional advice. See also *Eczema*, p. 300.

! Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Changes to freckles, moles, or warts
- Sudden swelling or allergic reaction
- Non-minor burns, including sunburn
- Shingles or suspected shingles
- Boils that do not disperse or burst
- Serious wounds, scrapes, bruising, bites, and stings

Minor Bites, Stings, & Swellings

Inflamed, swollen areas of skin are a common reaction to bites and stings. Although they can be very uncomfortable, most only cause local itching and inflammation, which usually subside within a few hours. All the remedies listed will help to ease irritation and soreness. For the most effective relief, use both an external and internal remedy. Lavender relieves irritation as well as being an insect repellent, aloe vera is soothing and healing, and both calendula and St. John's wort reduce inflammation. Echinacea stimulates the immune system and nettle is antiallergenic.

General cautions Seek immediate professional attention if prone to, or if there are signs of, extreme allergic reactions, or if there is a sting in the mouth and the throat starts to swell. Some stings and animal bites are poisonous and may need inoculations and immediate medical attention.

External Remedies

Herb Lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108)

Remedy Rub fresh leaves, neat tincture, or essential oil on and around the bite or sting.

Other uses This will also repel insects.

Herbs Sweet basil (*Ocimum basilicum*, p. 241), holy basil (*Ocimum tenuiflorum*, p. 116), sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Apply freshly squeezed juice from the leaves of one of the herbs.

Herbs Aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73), St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106)

Remedy Apply either aloe vera gel, calendula ointment, cream, lotion, or tincture, or St. John's wort oil. To make the calendula lotion, infuse 2 heaping tbsp of calendula in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Strain, cool, then apply.

Option Add 5 drops each of lavender (*Lavandula*

officinalis, p. 108) and German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77) essential oils to 1 tsp of one of the above preparations.

Caution Do not apply chamomile oil in pregnancy.

Tip Apply neat lemon juice (*Citrus limon*, p. 82) if there is nothing else available.

Internal Remedies

Herb Nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146)

Remedy Make an infusion and drink 1 $\frac{1}{2}$ cups (450 ml) a day, or take 1 tsp of tincture with water 3 times a day for up to 3 days.

Herb Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy Take tablets or tincture.

Skin Rashes, Minor Burns, & Sunburn

More annoying than debilitating, skin rashes and minor burns, including sunburn, usually clear up without assistance, although herbal treatment can speed recovery.

Hives (urticaria) are usually caused by an allergic reaction, but can also be triggered by heat, cold, or sunlight. They only last for a few hours but will often recur. For the most effective relief, apply chickweed cream and take one of the internal remedies.

Skin rashes have many causes, such as allergy, infection, irritation, bites, stings, and temperature changes. Use these remedies to alleviate itchiness and swelling.

Small-scale burns usually respond well to herbal medicine, but even small burns may be deep and can quickly become infected. Before using a remedy, bathe the burned area in clean, cold water and keep the area cool for up to 3 hours with a clean cotton cloth that has been soaked in cold water.

General caution If there is any sign of infection seek professional advice.

Hives (Urticaria)

Herbs Nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146), heartsease (*Viola tricolor*, p. 282), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy (Internal) Drink an infusion of 5 g of each herb and 3 cups (750 ml) of water regularly during the day. Repeat for 1 week. If symptoms persist, take for another week.

Herbs Dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141), yellow dock (*Rumex crispus*, p. 264), burdock (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65)

Remedy (Internal) Make a decoction with 5 g of each root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Drink 1 $\frac{1}{4}$ cups (300 ml) a day and repeat for at least 1 week.

Caution Do not take yellow dock in pregnancy.

Herb Chickweed (*Stellaria media*, p. 272)

Remedy (External) Apply cream as required.

Inflamed Skin Rashes

Herbs Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73), comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138)

Remedy Apply calendula or comfrey ointment, cream, or lotion to troubled areas 2–4 times a day. For the lotion, make an infusion, strain, cool, and then apply.

Caution Do not apply comfrey to broken skin.

Weeping Skin

Herbs Aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60), witch hazel (*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102)

Remedy Apply aloe vera gel or distilled witch hazel or witch hazel ointment to the affected area 2–4 times a day.

Minor Burns & Sunburn

Herbs Aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60), lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108)

Remedy Apply aloe vera gel or neat lavender essential oil to the affected area as needed.

Herb Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Infuse 1 heaping tbsp of herb in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Strain, cool, and apply as a lotion to the affected area as required.